

LESSON 1 · ART SCHOOL, BUT DIY

Linework & Basic Shapes

Your foundation in mark-making, line control, and geometric form.

Overview

Every drawing starts with a line. Before you can render light, construct perspective, or capture likeness, you need to trust your hand to make marks that go where you intend. This lesson builds that trust through deliberate, systematic practice.

The goal isn't perfect lines — it's confident lines. The difference is enormous. A hesitant, scratchy line tells the viewer your hand was uncertain. A bold, committed line — even if slightly off — reads as intentional. That confidence comes only from repetition.

CORE CONCEPTS

Pencil Grip & Pressure Control

There are two primary grips: the **writing grip** (overhand, for detail and small marks) and the **overhand grip** (underhand along the pencil shaft, for loose gestural marks and shading). Most beginners only use the writing grip — learning to alternate between them dramatically expands your expressive range.

Pressure control determines line weight. Practice drawing the same line at 10%, 50%, and 100% pressure. Each serves a different purpose: light pressure for underdrawing and construction, medium for finished linework, full pressure rarely (only for accent or deep shadow).

Ghosting Method

Before committing any mark to paper, rehearse the motion in the air above the surface — "ghost" the line 2–4 times. This trains your muscle memory for the arc. When you finally touch paper, you're executing a rehearsed motion, not improvising. This single habit improves line quality faster than any other technique.

Basic Geometric Forms

All complex objects can be broken into four fundamental forms: the **box**, **cylinder**, **sphere**, and **cone**. Before you can draw a face, a figure, or a building, you need to be able to draw these forms convincingly in 3D. Start with boxes — they teach you spatial reasoning faster than any other shape.

Ellipses

Ellipses are circles in perspective. They appear constantly: wheels, cups, eyes, planets. The key insight is that an ellipse has a **minor axis** (the narrow diameter) and a **major axis** (the wide diameter), and the minor axis always points through the center of the circle you're drawing in perspective. Ghost ellipses before committing, just like straight lines.

DAILY EXERCISES

EXERCISE 1

Ghosted Lines — 15 minutes

- Fill an A4 page with parallel lines drawn freehand using the ghosting method.
- Vary spacing between lines. Aim for consistent spacing, but don't measure.
- Try horizontal, vertical, and diagonal orientations.
- On a second page, draw lines connecting dot pairs you've pre-marked. Focus on start/end accuracy.

EXERCISE 2

Ellipse Drill — 10 minutes

- Fill a page with ellipses of varying widths (very narrow to nearly circular).
- Ghost each ellipse 3x before touching paper. Draw through the ellipse (2 full rotations).
- Aim for smooth, confident ellipses — not tight, hesitant ones.
- Draw ellipses inside boxes you've sketched freehand to practice perspective circles.

EXERCISE 3

Form Construction — 20 minutes

- Draw 5 boxes from imagination. Attempt 2-point perspective (two vanishing points on the horizon).
- Add cylinders: draw two ellipses stacked, connect their edges with parallel verticals.
- Shade each form using only two values: the lit side and the shadow side. No gradients.
- Sketch one everyday object (mug, shoe, phone) and identify its underlying geometric forms.

CURATED FREE RESOURCES**How to Hold and Control Your Pencil — Proko**youtube.com/@Proko · Video

Pencil basics — grip, pressure, control fundamentals. Watch first.

Draw a Box — Lesson 1drawabox.com/lesson/1 · Free Course

One of the best free structured drawing programs. Lessons on lines, ellipses, and boxes.

Making Marks — New Masters Academyyoutube.com/@NewMastersAcademy · Video

Complete overview of what a pencil can do. Essential for beginners.

Drawing Basics — Lines (Playlist)youtube.com · Video Series

Structured intro to line quality and construction. Work through videos sequentially.

Learn How to Draw Pt. 1: Lines, Lines, Linesyoutube.com · Video

First in a 3-part series on building strong line habits through structured exercises.

How to Improve Line Quality — Draftsmen Podcastyoutube.com · Video

Advice on making your lines feel confident and intentional. Quick, practical tips.

Rendering in Pen and Ink — Playlistyoutube.com · Video Series

Videos 3–7 focused on smooth confident linework with ink.

Art Warm Up & Exercisesyoutube.com · Video

Daily warm-up exercises for the start of every session. Build this habit.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

Every day: Fill at least one page with line exercises before doing anything else. Ghosted lines, ellipses, hatching, boxes. The goal isn't perfection — it's building muscle memory through repetition.

Weekly: Pick one everyday object and draw it using only basic shapes. No detail, just underlying geometry.